

S02-04 - After the Ambush

Player read-aloud

The road is quiet again, except for the horses breathing hard and the forest shifting around the wreckage.

Scene summary

The party regroup and may learn the Bramble Union were targeting the cargo specifically.

Visible choices

- Loot bodies
- Interrogate survivor
- Leave quickly
- Mark graves

Player questions

- What detail in After the Ambush tells you the official story is incomplete?
- Who notices the human cost first, and how do they show it?
- What small object, smell, or sound makes this scene feel real?

GM notes

- If players loot bodies, include personal details, not just coins. Make the world feel lived-in.
- Keep player-facing information actionable. Reveal systemic truth through objects, reactions, and consequences before naming it.
- Manufactured-threat lens: seed the contradiction, do not explain it. The surface goal stays simple and heroic.
- [ADD/EARNED] A spared/captured reclamer says monster attacks spiked when protection contracts went on sale. (Presence Medium 15; requires mercy or capture)

Checks and rolls

- Presence or Knowledge Interrogate, comfort, or read the aftermath. Easy to standard
Convert combat result into actionable truth. 10/15 Cleanly resolve: Interrogate, comfort, or read the aftermath. Add a concrete boon, extra clue, or improved position. Success, plus the player names one helpful detail or asks one follow-up question. Success, but the GM exposes a cost, ticks a countdown, or reveals a new pressure tied to After the Ambush. The full goal slips, but the party still learns a useful truth or avoids the worst consequence. The GM makes a hard move that follows from the fiction and leaves the next choice visible. Spend Fear to reveal omitted risk, split attention, or put a human cost in front of the contract. On mixed or sliding results, reveal information in layers: visible fact, actionable clue, then

systemic truth.

Clues

- Personal effects They were people. Their violence is still violence. Keepsakes show the reclaimers had lives and obligations.
- Earned seed Available if players investigate, show mercy, or ask the right question. A spared/captured reclaimer says monster attacks spiked when protection contracts went on sale. Presence Medium 15; requires mercy or capture

Loot

- Personal effects
- Route sketch
- Old Goldspire seal
- Bramble Union Stoneweave: A garment of thousands of tiny polished stones moves like cloth and turns thorns like armor. Every fitted piece looks cut by hands that loved the work.
- Vial of Briarpowder: A small stoppered vial holds fine grey-green thorn powder that seems to drink the light. A blade edge near it looks sharper and hungrier.
- Bramble Ward-Scrap Charm Cluster: A knot of blue ward shards, twine, and tiny salvage tags clacks softly at a Bramblefolk belt. It looks illegal only because it looks useful.
- Claimrunner Serrated Blade: A short serrated blade shows careful filing along the back edge and a handle wrapped in road cord. It is ugly in the practical way of a tool that has never had a decorative day.

Mechanics

- Plot So Far: The party is in Act Two pressure: The party regroups and may learn the Bramble Union were targeting the cargo specifically.
- Mechanics In Play: Use Daggerheart Duality Dice as baseline. Use the listed Difficulty and outcome options when a roll matters. Keep trivial actions no-roll; roll only when uncertainty, cost, or danger is interesting.
- Roll Cards: s02-04-question-a-spared-reclamer S02-04 Question a spared reclaimer Question a spared reclaimer Presence Knowledge Presence Knowledge 12 Presence keeps them talking; Knowledge asks the right claim question. A living prisoner becomes a person or a problem. Critical Success: best possible version of the action; gain Hope and clear 1 Stress. Add an extra benefit that follows from the fiction. Success with Hope: the PC gets what they wanted and gains Hope. Keep the position clean or generous. Success with Fear: the PC gets what they wanted, but the GM gains Fear and introduces a cost, complication, or pressure. Failure with Hope: the PC does not get the full result, but gains Hope and receives a useful thread, clue, or safer next option. Failure with Fear: the PC fails and the GM gains Fear. Make a hard move that follows from the fiction. A living prisoner becomes a person or a...
- Gm Fear Spends: Close the ambush net or put a PC between cargo and a frightened reclaimer. Reveal a personal effect that makes victory emotionally complicated.
- Conditions Hazards: No official condition unless a feature, hazard, or fictional

position calls for Hidden, Restrained, or Vulnerable.

- Search Loot Clues: Claimrunner and ambusher search: half-written letter, old Goldspire seal, reclaimed keyring, names that complicate victory.
- No Roll Guidance: Do not call for a roll when the players have time, a clear method, and no meaningful pressure.
- Escalation: Escalate by making cost visible: time, noise, trust, ward instability, or someone vulnerable in danger.
- Deescalation: De-escalate through respect, care, honest testimony, useful evidence, or a concrete concession.
- Tv Mechanics Caption: Public cue: After the Ambush asks what the party does, what it costs, and who is protected.
- Trait Variety Note: Primary traits in this scene: Finesse, Knowledge, Presence. If rolls drift toward Instinct/Presence, ask whether Agility, Strength, Finesse, or Knowledge better describes the action.
- Class Community Ancestry Reveals: Loreborne: spots older legal, heraldic, or ward-craft language under the branding. Underborne: notices service doors, hidden routes, and who built the thing nobody credits. Highborne: reads etiquette, class panic, and reputational risk. Ridgeborne: notices stonework, weight, pressure, and structural weakness. Wildborne: reads the land, animals, and local ecological stress.
Elf/Ribbet/Human/Giant/Katari: invite one sensory or social detail from the player's heritage. Sorcerer/Rogue/Warrior/Guardian/Ranger: give each class one table-facing way to shine without changing the plot.

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